Haji Khan Kakar and the other chiefs who had declared for Shuja were followed by Keane, Cotton, Nott and the various British army commanders. They passed out of the Herat Gate and through an avenue formed by the tattered troopers of Shah Shuja's Contingent. To the sound of an Indian regimental brass band playing an English anthem – God Save the King – Shuja was ceremonially enthroned as King of Afghanistan, while the Army of the Indus marched past in all its ragged glory. Cannon fired a 101-gun salute and bags of Indian rupees were thrown into the disappointingly small crowd of Afghans who had assembled to watch the spectacle. 'Everyone became rich!' wrote Mohammad Husain, a merchant of Herat who was one of Shuja's more enthusiastic followers, and his first posthumous biographer.

> His Majesty ordered two lakhs of rupees to be given out for relief of the poor. Those who, in the time of the Barakzais, were too poor to be able even to tie a donkey in their own backyards, now were able to afford luxury saddles for horses and camels; their purses were full of silver coins, their hearts free of care. Indeed, money was so common that little children played with gold and silver coins in the alleys. Such was the benevolence of His Majesty and the English towards the soldiery and peasantry![56]

Yet, for all this optimism among the Shah's supporters, an event took place immediately after this durbar that is not referred to in a single British source, but which according to all the Afghan accounts was crucial in beginning the process of discrediting Shah Shuja in the eyes of his new subjects. Mohammad Husain Herati gives the earliest as well as the fullest account of what happened. 'At this time, an unfortunate incident occurred,' he wrote.

> A girl from a good family was going about her business when an inebriated foreign soldier crossed her path, grabbed her and dragged her into a near-by water-channel where he took her virginity. The girl's shrieks alerted passers-by to her unhappy fate, and they ran to inform her family: a large crowd gathered, including sayyids and clerics, and went to demand justice from His Majesty. Even though apologies were offered and regrets expressed, the Afghans, who are most sensitive on these points of honour, were bitter in their hearts, saying: 'If, at the beginning of this foreign occupation, such an outrage to a girl of noble lineage can be countenanced, and if the current state of affairs continues, then no one's honour will be safe! It is becoming clear that His Majesty is a mere puppet and a king in name only!'

Herati went on to explain that: